Startup pitch structure

Working format: approximately 15 minutes, with a separate hardware demonstration and no funding ask. This is a synthesis of the sources in the reading list, adapted for an early-stage team. It is not an official YC or Sequoia template.

1. What do you do?

- Product or service, target customer, and primary outcome.
- A brief explanation of the offering in plain language.
- Current development stage.

2. What customer problem are you solving?

- Target segment and relevant context; distinguish end user, buyer, and decision-maker.
- The unmet need, its frequency, severity, and consequences.
- Current workarounds and the limitations customers experience.
- Supporting interviews, observations, behavioral data, or credible research, with sources and sample context.

3. What is your solution, and why should it work?

- Core offering and how the customer experiences it.
- The insight connecting customer evidence to the proposed solution.
- Main benefits, the mechanism expected to deliver them, and relevant customer costs or effort.
- A simple use case, diagram, or storyboard where useful.
- Distinguish implemented capabilities from proposed ones; include relevant validation beside the claim it supports.

4. How large is the opportunity, and why now?

- Size and commercial characteristics of the defined target segment.
- A bottom-up estimate with explicit customer counts, purchase frequency, price, and time horizon; distinguish one-time and recurring revenue where relevant.
- The realistically reachable portion of the market, supported by access and distribution assumptions.
- Specific changes in behavior, technology, cost, or distribution that make the opportunity timely.
- TAM/SAM/SOM only where useful; define their boundaries and avoid overlapping or double-counted estimates.

5. Why would customers choose you?

- Direct competitors, indirect alternatives, and the status quo.
- Comparison using customer-relevant benefits and sacrifices: price, effort, setup, maintenance, reliability, or switching costs.
- Evidence supporting differentiation; identify untested advantages.
- Any credible source of defensibility, meaning what could make the advantage difficult to copy or displace, and its current maturity.

6. How will the business acquire customers and make money?

- Who pays, for what, how much, and how often.
- Pricing evidence or explicit pricing hypotheses.
- Initial acquisition and distribution channels, purchase process, and adoption barriers.
- Main delivery and service costs; preliminary unit economics, meaning the revenue and associated costs of serving a customer or selling a unit.
- What supports continued use, repeat purchase, or renewal, where relevant.
- More advanced models, such as lifetime value, only when the underlying assumptions can be explained.

7. What progress and validation do you have?

- Relevant completed work over a stated period.
- The strongest experiment, pilot, usage, purchase, or performance results appropriate to the stage.
- What those results establish, what remains unproven, and what changed as a consequence.
- Relevant metrics with definitions, denominators, timeframes, and meaningful baselines where available.
- A concise synthesis of progress and learning; supporting evidence also remains beside its relevant claim in earlier sections.

8. Why can this team execute, and what happens next?

- Relevant capabilities and concrete evidence of execution.
- Critical capability gaps, dependencies, or partnerships; distinguish confirmed arrangements from intentions.
- The few risks or assumptions most capable of undermining the proposition.
- Next tests and milestones linked to those uncertainties.
- Required resources, approximate timing, and measurable success criteria.

Rules for the whole deck

- Use takeaway headlines supported by evidence; keep one main point per slide.
- Keep the opening brief; explain the solution in section 3 and comparative advantage in section 5.
- Distinguish facts, interpretations, assumptions, and future plans.
- Match claim strength to evidence strength; reported preferences, observed behavior, purchases, repeated use, and technical tests support different conclusions.
- Keep user value and buyer value distinct where they differ.
- Use models and visuals only when they clarify the argument; define necessary terminology and move supporting detail to the appendix.
- Treat sections as content responsibilities, not fixed slide counts; select and rehearse for the available time.
- Close by reinforcing the central proposition, intended outcome, and next milestone; no funding ask is required.

Hardware demonstration, separate from the pitch

Demonstrate selected capabilities, identify live versus simulated elements, and state what the demonstration establishes and what requires further testing.